Topic 10 — Sikhism

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Sikhism | Guru (गुरु) Tradition | Ten Sikh Gurus | Guru Granth (गुरु ग्रंथ) Sahib (गुरु ग्रंथ साहिब) | Khalsa (खालसा) | Guru Gobind Singh (गुरु गोबिंद सिंह)

Sources baked in: NCERT *Themes in Indian History Part II*, RS Sharma *Medieval India*, UPPCS Prelims PYQs 2018–2025, Ghatnachakra Indian History (Sikh / Maratha / Later Mughal) **Weight:** ★★★ — 10-Guru order, Adi Granth vs eternal Granth, Arjan/Tegh martyrdom pair, Khalsa 1699, Mardana direction **Last verified:** September 2026 **Current Affairs:** N/A (purely historical)

10.1 Sikhism — Identity

Founder: Guru Nanak (गुरु नानक) | **1469–1539** | **Punjab** (Talwandi / Nankana Sahib)

- Sikhism is a **monotheistic** panth built on **Ik Onkar** (one formless God).
- It grew in a Bhakti (भक्ति) milieu but became a **separate institution** with ten Gurus, a scripture, and later the Khalsa.
- **Kabir did not found Sikhism.** His hymns later entered the Granth.
- The ethical triad is **Naam Japna**, **Kirat Karni**, and **Vand Chakna**.
- Nanak taught the **householder** path.
- Extreme ascetic escape is not the Sikh ideal.
- **Langar** is the free community kitchen.
- It is an equality practice, not a tax.
- **Sangat** is the congregation for hymn and counsel.
- A **Sikh** means a learner of the Guru.
- **Khalsa** later means the initiated order of **1699**.
- **Mardana** was Nanak's Muslim **rabab** companion and **disciple**.

[!TIP] **Exam Anchor — Disciple-Guru Match (UPPCS 2025 Spine):** - **Kabir:** Swami Ramananda (Varanasi, initiated with divine name *Rama*) - **Amir Khusrau:** Hazrat Nizamuddin Auliya (Chishti master at Delhi) - **Surdas:** Mahaprabhu Vallabhacharya (*Pushtimarg* / Ashtachhap) - **Bhai Mardana:** Guru Nanak Dev (Lifelong Muslim companion & rabab minstrel across *Udasis*)

10.2 Guru Tradition

- There are exactly **10 human Gurus** from Nanak to Gobind Singh (**1469–1708**).
- Each Guru **nominated** the next. It was not automatic eldest-son inheritance.

- **Guru Angad** succeeded Nanak though he was not Nanak's son.
- From **Amar Das** through **Arjan**, leadership tightened inside one family line.
- The Guru was both spiritual guide and community head.
- In **1708** Gobind Singh ended human guruship.
- **Guru Granth Sahib** is the eternal Guru.
- There is **no 11th human Guru**.
- **Mata Khivi** is remembered for langar service under the early Gurus.

10.3 Ten Sikh Gurus

#	Guru	Years	One fact
1	**Nanak**	1469–1539	Founder
2	**Angad**	1539–1552	**Gurmukhi**
3	**Amar Das**	1552–1574	Langar; **22 Manjis**; **Goindwal**
4	**Ram Das**	1574–1581	**Amritsar** (Akbar grant / Bibi Bhani)
5	**Arjan Dev**	1581–1606	**Adi Granth 1604**; Masand; martyred **1606**
6	**Hargobind**	1606–1644	**Miri-Piri**; **Akal Takht**
7	**Har Rai**	1644–1661	Kept the armed tradition quietly
8	**Har Krishan**	1661–1664	**Child Guru**; died in **Delhi**
9	**Tegh Bahadur**	1665–1675	Martyred **1675** under **Aurangzeb**
10	**Gobind Singh**	1675–1708	**Khalsa 1699**; Granth eternal

- **Guru Nanak** appointed **Bhai Lehna** as successor; Lehna became **Guru Angad**.
- Nanak's son **Sri Chand** (श्रीचंद) did **not** become Guru.
- **Guru Angad** is remembered as the progenitor of the **Gurmukhi** script (लिपि).
- **Guru Amar Das** divided the Sikh religious organisation into **22 Manjis**.
- Each **Manji** (मंजी) was placed under a local Sikh preacher.
- **Akbar** donated about **500 bighas** of land with a natural pond to **Bibi Bhani**, wife of **Guru Ram Das**.
- The settlement on that grant was first called **Ramdaspur**.
- It later became **Amritsar**, named after the sacred tank (**Amrit Sarovar**).
- **Guru Arjan Dev** built **Sri Harmandir Sahib** in the middle of the Amritsar tank.
- He founded the towns of **Tarn Taran** and **Kartarpur**.
- He organised the **Masand** custom: Sikhs paid about **one-tenth** of income to the Guru.
- When Prince **Khusrau** fled toward Punjab in **1606**, Guru Arjan gave him blessings and some help.
- **Jahangir** (जहाँगीर) treated that act as disloyalty and ordered Arjan's death by torture.
- **Guru Angad** standardised **Gurmukhi** for Punjabi hymns.

- **Guru Amar Das** made **langar** a firm rule at **Goindwal**.
- **Guru Ram Das** founded the **Amritsar** settlement and its sacred tank.
- **Guru Arjan** compiled the **Adi Granth in 1604** and developed **Harmandir Sahib**.
- Arjan was the **first Guru martyr**, executed under **Jahangir in 1606**.
- **1604** is the year of compilation.
- **1606** is the year of martyrdom.
- Do not swap those dates.
- **Guru Hargobind** wore two swords.
- **Piri** stood for spiritual authority.
- **Miri** stood for temporal authority.
- He built the **Akal Takht** beside Harmandir as the seat of worldly authority.
- Hargobind began armed discipline.
- He did **not** create the Khalsa.
- **Guru Har Krishan** is the **8th** Guru.
- He was a child remembered for service in a **Delhi** epidemic.
- **Guru Tegh Bahadur** was executed in **Delhi in 1675** under **Aurangzeb**.
- narrative links Tegh Bahadur with defending **Kashmiri Pandits'** right to their faith.
- **Guru Gobind Singh** is the **10th** and last human Guru.

10.4 Guru Granth Sahib

- **Guru Arjan Dev** compiled the **Adi Granth in 1604**.
- It was installed at **Harmandir Sahib, Amritsar**.
- **Gurmukhi** is the script of the corpus.
- **Japji Sahib** of Nanak opens the Granth.
- The Adi Granth carries compositions of **six Sikh Gurus** plus many bhagats.
- Among the earliest compositions is that of the Bengali Vaishnava poet **Jayadev**.
- Among the last human Guru compositions added is that of **Guru Tegh Bahadur**.
- The Granth includes hymns of **Kabir** (कबीर).
- It includes hymns of **Namdev** (नामदेव).
- It includes hymns of **Ravidas**.
- It includes hymns of **Sheikh Farid**.
- Bhagat bani does not make those saints Sikh founders.
- Hymns of **Guru Tegh Bahadur** were added before the final canon.
- In **1708** Gobind Singh declared **Guru Granth Sahib** the eternal Guru.
- **Adi Granth** names the 1604 book.
- **Guru Granth Sahib** names the same canon as living Guru after 1708.
- **Dasam Granth** is a separate corpus attributed to Gobind Singh.
- It is **not** the eternal Guru.

- A **granthi** reads the scripture.
- The Granth is the Guru.
- The granthi is not.

10.5 Khalsa

Vaisakhi 1699 | Anandpur Sahib | Guru Gobind Singh

- The Khalsa is the **initiated** Sikh brotherhood, not a Mughal land category.
- **Mughal Khalsa** means **crown land** — not the Sikh **Khalsa** of 1699.
- The first five initiates are the **Panj Pyare**.
- **Bhai Daya Singh** is one of the Panj Pyare.
- **Bhai Dharam Singh** is one of the Panj Pyare.
- **Bhai Himmat Singh** is one of the Panj Pyare.
- **Bhai Mohkam Singh** is one of the Panj Pyare.
- **Bhai Sahib Singh** is one of the Panj Pyare.
- The Guru took amrit from them after initiating them.
- That act symbolised equality.
- **Amrit Sanchar** uses sweetened water stirred with a **khanda**.
- **Kesh** means uncut hair.
- **Kangha** is the comb.
- **Kara** is the steel bracelet.
- **Kachha** is the short breeches.
- **Kirpan** is the sword of defence.
- Initiated men take the name **Singh**.
- Initiated women take **Kaur**.
- The ideal is **sant-sipahi** (saint-soldier).
- Khalsa was **not** created at Amritsar and **not** by Nanak, Arjan, or Hargobind.

10.6 Guru Gobind Singh

Guru Arjan martyrdom (1606) — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Jahangir saw the growing Sikh community and **Guru Arjan's** support for **Khusrau** as a political threat. **Course:** Guru Arjan was arrested and tortured in Lahore. **Result:** He became the first Sikh **martyr**. The succession (उत्तराधिकार क्रम) passed to **Guru Hargobind**, who militarised the tradition with the **miri–piri** concept.

Guru Tegh Bahadur martyrdom (1675) — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Kashmiri Pandits sought protection against **Aurangzeb's** religious pressure. Guru Tegh Bahadur challenged forced conversion policy. **Course:** He was arrested at **Malikpur** and brought to Delhi. He

refused to accept Islam. **Result:** He was executed in **1675**. His son **Guru Gobind Singh** became the next Guru and later founded the **Khalsa (1699)**.

Battle of Bhangani (1688) — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Hill Rajas of the **Shivalik** (शिवालिक) zone resented Guru Gobind Singh's growing power at **Anandpur** (आनंदपुर). **Course:** Allied hill chiefs attacked the Guru's forces near **Bhangani**. The Guru's Sikhs and allies defeated the hill coalition (गठबंधन). **Result:** Sikh military credibility rose before the formal **Khalsa** institution and later Mughal conflict.

10th Guru | 1675–1708 | Born **Gobind Rai**, son of Tegh Bahadur

- He was born in **1666 at Patna** (Bihar).
- He became Guru in **1675** after his father's martyrdom in Delhi.
- **Anandpur Sahib** was his fortified base and the Khalsa site.
- **Battle of Bhangani (1688)** was fought against **Pahari hill rajas**, before 1699.
- After 1699 came sieges and battles such as **Chamkaur** and **Muktsar**.
- Tradition remembers the martyrdom of his **four (चातुर्याम) sons**.
- **Zafarnama** is his **Persian** letter to **Aurangzeb**.
- He died in **1708** at **Nanded** (Maharashtra), assassinated by an Afghan noble in the traditional narrative.
- **Takhat Sachkhand Sri Hazur Sahib** (Huzur Sahib) marks his mausoleum site.
- The same year he closed the human line and left **Guru Granth Sahib** as Guru.
- **Banda Bahadur**'s earlier name was **Lachman Dev** (also written Lachhman Dev).
- Guru Gobind Singh gave him the name by which Sikh history (इतिहास) remembers him.
- **Hem Kund Sahib** in **Chamoli, Uttarakhand**, is a major Sikh pilgrimage gurudwara linked to Gobind Singh tradition.
- Later Sikh polity (Misls, **Ranjit Singh** (रणजीत सिंह)) is modern-history continuity, not an 11th Guru.

> **Logic:** Last **human** Guru = **Gobind Singh**. Eternal Guru = **Guru Granth Sahib**.

10.7 Master Fact-Locks — Sikh Guru Lineage, Institutions & Geography

Entity / Concept	Canonical Facts & Historical Specifics	High-Yield Exam Lock
1. Guru Nanak Dev (1469–1539)	• Born at **Talwandi (Nankana Sahib)**, Punjab (now Pakistan); died at **Kartarpur**. • Preached *Nirguna Bhakti*, divine unity (*Ik Onkar*), founded the *Sangat* (congregation) and *Pangat / Langar* (free community kitchen). • Selected **Bhai Lehna** as successor, naming him **Angad** (*"limb of my body"*), bypassing his own sons Sri Chand (who founded the ascetic *Udasi* sect) and Lakhmi Das.	Founder of Sikhism

Entity / Concept	Canonical Facts & Historical Specifics	High-Yield Exam Lock
2. Guru Angad (1539–1552)	• Progenitor / developer of the **Gurmukhi script**. • Formalized and expanded the *Langar* institution; compiled Guru Nanak's hymns.	Originator of Gurmukhi
3. Guru Amar Das (1552–1574)	• Divided the spiritual administration into **22 diocese / branches called Manjis**, each headed by a devout Sikh preacher. • Advocated strongly against *Purdah* and *Sati*; visited by Emperor Akbar at Goindwal.	22 Manjis administrative network
4. Guru Ram Das (1574–1581)	• Akbar granted **500 Bighas of land** containing a natural pool to his wife **Bibi Bhani**. • Founded the sacred city of **Ramdaspur**, later renamed **Amritsar** after the sacred pool (*Amrit Sarovar*).	Foundation of Amritsar
5. Guru Arjan Dev (1581–1606)	• Compiled the holy scripture **Adi Granth** in **1604 CE** at Amritsar. • Constructed **Sri Harmandir Sahib** (Golden Temple) in the center of the Amritsar pool; foundation stone laid by Sufi saint Mian Mir. • Founded the cities of **Tarn Taran** and **Kartarpur** (Jalandhar). • Instituted the **Masand system** (requiring Sikhs to contribute one-tenth of their income, *Dasvandh*, to the Guru). • **Martyrdom (1606 CE):** Gave shelter, blessings, and financial support to the rebel prince Khusrau; summoned, fined, and sentenced to execution under torture by Emperor **Jahangir** (first great Sikh martyrdom).	Compilation of Adi Granth & 1st Martyrdom
Adi Granth Composition Details	• Contains sacred hymns of six Sikh Gurus (Nanak, Angad, Amar Das, Ram Das, Arjan Dev, and later Tegh Bahadur). • Includes compositions of 15 Bhakti and Sufi saints: Kabir, Baba Farid, Namdev, Ravidas, Dhanna, Pipa, Sain, Trilochan, Jaidev, Ramananda. • **Earliest poet:** 12th-century Bengali Vaishnava poet **Jayadeva** (author of *Gita Govinda*). • **Chronologically latest hymns:** Added by 10th Guru Gobind Singh from the hymns of **Guru Tegh Bahadur**.	Hymns & syncretic contributors
6. Guru Hargobind (1606–1644)	• Adopted the policy of militarization; wore two swords representing **Miri** (temporal authority) and **Piri** (spiritual authority). • Built the **Akal Takht** (Throne of the Timeless) opposite Harmandir Sahib; fortified Amritsar (*Lohgarh*).	Miri & Piri doctrine
7. Guru Har Rai (1644–1661)	Maintained a standing cavalry; provided medical aid to Prince Dara Shikoh.	Peaceful consolidation
8. Guru Har Krishan (1661–1664)	Acceded as the child Guru (age 5); served smallpox victims in Delhi; passed away at age 8 (*"Bal Guru"*).	Youngest Guru

Entity / Concept	Canonical Facts & Historical Specifics	High-Yield Exam Lock
9. Guru Tegh Bahadur (1664–1675)	• Revered as *Hind di Chadar* (Shield of India). • Protested against Aurangzeb's religious persecution and defended the freedom of Kashmiri Pandits. • Summoned to Delhi, refused conversion to Islam, and was publicly beheaded at **Chandni Chowk, Delhi** in November **1675 CE** on the orders of Emperor **Aurangzeb** (Gurudwara Sis Ganj Sahib marks the martyrdom site; Gurudwara Rakab Ganj marks the cremation site).	2nd Martyrdom (Aurangzeb)
10. Guru Gobind Singh (1675–1708)	• Born in **1666 CE at Patna** (Bihar); fought against hill Rajas (Battle of Bhangani, 1688). • Founded the military order of the **Khalsa Panth** on **Baisakhi (13 April 1699)** at **Anandpur Sahib**. • Mandated the **Five Ks (Kakars):** *Kesh* (uncut hair), *Kangha* (wooden comb), *Kara* (iron bracelet), *Kachhera* (cotton undergarment), *Kirpan* (curved dagger). • Ordained universal surnames: **Singh** (Lion) for men and **Kaur** (Princess) for women. • Composed the Persian epistle ***Zafarnama*** (Epistle of Victory) addressed to Aurangzeb. • Assassinated at **Nanded** (Maharashtra) in 1708 by an Afghan mercenary; his mausoleum is enshrined at **Takhat Sachkhand Sri Hazur Abchalnagar Sahib**. • Declared the termination of human guruship, investing eternal spiritual authority in the **Guru Granth Sahib**.	Khalsa Panth & Nanded Mausoleum
Banda Singh Bahadur (1670–1716)	• Original name: **Lachman Dev** (or Madho Das Bairagi); named Banda Singh Bahadur by Guru Gobind Singh at Nanded. • Led massive peasant rebellion in Punjab, established Sikh sovereignty, struck coins in the names of Guru Nanak and Guru Gobind Singh, abolished the Zamindari system. • Executed at Delhi in 1716 under Emperor Farrukh Siyar.	First Sikh sovereign military leader
Hemkund Sahib	Famous Sikh shrine located at high altitude in **Chamoli district, Uttarakhand**, associated with the pre-incarnation penance of Guru Gobind Singh mentioned in the *Bachittar Natak*.	Sacred Himalayan shrine